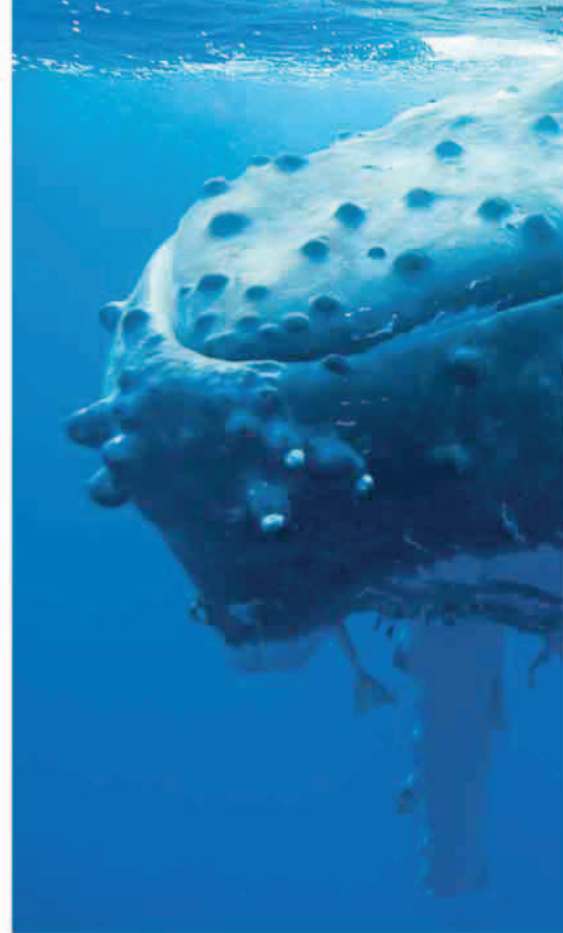


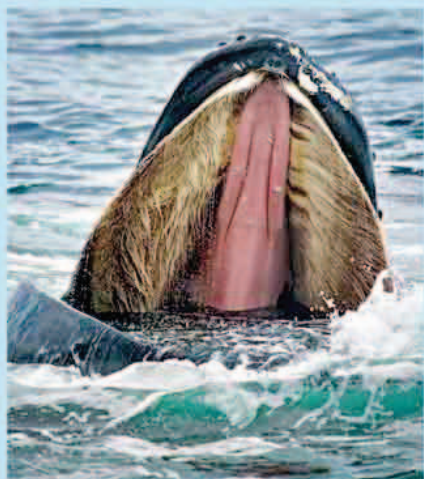
Baleen whales

The biggest animals in the oceans are the baleen whales, which include the largest animal that has ever lived—the colossal blue whale. They are called baleen whales because, instead of teeth, they have fine comblike plates made of a fibrous material called baleen. These whales, similar to the giant filter-feeding sharks and manta rays, use the plates to strain small animals from the water. But different species have different ways of catching their food. The whales are highly intelligent, and some regularly work together to round up prey. They can communicate using a wide variety of moans, wails, and clicks.



BALEEN PLATES

A whale's baleen plates are made of keratin—the same material as your hair and fingernails. The plates form long, bristly combs attached to each side of the upper jaw, and they hang down so they fill the gap between the whale's upper and lower jaw when its mouth is open. When feeding, the whale uses various techniques to fill its mouth with water and force it out through the plates. These then trap any small prey such as copepods, krill, and small fish.



Bowhead whale

Arctic specialist



Length Up to 66 ft (20 m)

Weight Up to 110 tons (100 metric tons)

Habitat or range Arctic

Named for its upwardly arched jaw, the bowhead specializes in gathering tiny copepods from the icy waters of the Arctic Ocean and nearby cold seas. Unlike other baleen whales, it feeds by swimming with its mouth open. This forces water in at the front of its jaws, and out through the very long baleen plates at the side.

Gray whale

Seafloor feeder

Length Up to 49 ft (15 m)

Weight Up to 40 tons (36 metric tons)

Habitat or range Coastal north Pacific

Uniquely for a baleen whale, the gray whale feeds on animals that it gathers from the seabed. It does this by swimming along the bottom on its side to plow up soft mud. The whale draws this into its mouth, then pumps it out through its baleen to trap prey.

